

USC Upstate to Hold Second Ring Ceremony in May

By: Mary Kathryn Chandler



The University of South Carolina Upstate will hold its second-ever Ring Ceremony on Saturday, May 3, 2025. The ceremony will be held in front of the Stockwell Administration building, marking the continuation of a new, meaningful campus tradition.

The first ceremony took place last fall and was established to give students and alumni a significant moment to celebrate their achievements and connection to the university. During this semester's ceremony, 24 students will be honored. "There are two things that we envision for our students here on campus: one is that every student has a passport, and the other is that every student graduates with a USC Upstate ring," said Charlianne Nestlen, the Director of Alumni Relations.

Before last year, USC Upstate did not have an official class ring. Student, faculty, and alumni opinions were considered when designing the official ring, which has the distinctive design that incorporates the University's shield logo and the iconic gold dome of the Stockwell Building. "The dome is something that resonates with everyone," said Charlianne. "Even if you were one of the first students, the dome hasn't changed; mascots, logos, and names have all changed. The dome has remained resilient."

USC Upstate is the first of the University of South Carolina's satellite campuses to establish a ring ceremony. Family, friends, and alumni are encouraged to attend to support the Spartans as they receive their rings. Before the ceremony, the rings will all spend the night together under the Stockwell Administration Building. "Then came the ceremony, we wanted something that would be timeless," said Charlianne, "that would be a tradition, that would be symbolic for everyone who has come to USC Upstate." Outside the Stockwell building is the Sorenson fountain, where there will be a traditional ring dip in the fountain to bond everyone in their

experience of receiving the ring. This is something that the school hopes will be a part of all future ring ceremonies.

For students, receiving a class ring is more than just acquiring a piece of jewelry. “Students will wear the ring daily, and their diploma will hang in their office, and they can say, 'I’m a proud alumni of USC Upstate,” said Walker Smith, Assistant Director of Annual Giving.

The Ring Ceremony is expected to become a permanent part of USC Upstate’s culture, taking place each fall during Family and Alumni Weekend. “Rituals and traditions help to make a school a destination, to elevate the school pride, and say I wanna be a Spartan,” said Chancellor Bennie Harris.

Students must have completed at least 60 credit hours to receive a class ring. Alumni who did not previously have the chance to receive a USC Upstate ring can purchase one and participate in the ceremony. Those interested can contact the Office of Alumni Engagement.